

Response Letter with Annotations

Citation (APA format, using Zotero or other bibliography software)

Yang, T., Yang, X., Peng, Y., & Mukerjee, S. (2025). Are partisan, unreliable, digital-born, and mass-oriented media more likely to thrive on social media? Comparing four information ecosystems. *Journal of Communication*. <https://doi.org/10.1093/joc/jqaf035>

Annotations

1. Purposes

a. Motivation (one-sentence summary)

This study developed a theoretical framework based on structuration theory that examines the dyadic relationships among platforms, agents, and media, focusing on four factors, institutional legacy, information reliability, ideological differences, and news inequalities, using data from three social media platforms (Facebook, Twitter, and YouTube) as well as web traffic data to explain differences in news exposure among audiences.

b. Specific Rationale (several bullet points)

- Social media platforms as gatekeepers to manage news visibilities, making them gain power over relationship between new media and audience
- Social media platforms have distinct affordances. Multiplatform research - comprehensive appraisals and contingencies of platformication dynamics.

c. Research Questions and/or Hypotheses

H1. Legacy media outlets, including newspapers (H1a), broadcast/TV (H1b), and magazines (H1c), attract less audience engagement on social media platforms than digital-born media relative on social media platforms than digital-born media relative to their web traffic.

H2: Low-reliability media outlets attract greater audience engagement on social media platforms relative to web traffic than high-reliability media outlets.

H3: Partisan media outlets secure more audience engagement on social media relative to their web traffic than non-partisan media outlets.

H4: Right-wing media outlets attract more audience engagement on social media relative to their web traffic than left-wing media outlets.

H5: Media outlets attracting audiences with relatively low education level (H5a) and lower incomes (H5b) attract more audience engagement on social media relative to their web traffic.

H6. Media outlets attracting younger audiences gain more audience engagement on social media relative to their web traffic.

H7. Media outlets attracting more female audience members gain more audience engagement on social media relative to their web traffic.

RQ: How do the factors that shape the platformized visibilities of media outlets on Twitter, YouTube, and Facebook (relative to web traffic) differ.

- Identify IV, DV, mediator, moderator

IVs: Institutional legacy, information reliability, media partisanship, and news inequalities (education, income, gender, and age)

DV: Visibility

Moderators: Platforms

- Identify specific relationships among variables

Four factors (IVs): Institutional legacy, information reliability, media partisanship and news inequalities -> Platforms (Youtube, Facebook and Twitter) -> News visibility (engagement)

2. Method

a. Research Design

Observational data extracted from N=650 news media outlets that have accounts on Twitter, Facebook and Youtube.

Web - from ComScore - web visits

Twitter - API - tweets

Facebook - CrowdTangle - posts

Youtube - API - videos

Total of N = 8.4 million posts analyzed

b. Sample (representative sample?)

Six-month time window Feb 2022 - July 2022 to enhance reliability.

Outlets selected from five previous studies. Representative of widely used outlets in the USA. Major social media platforms.

c. Measures

Institutional legacy - manually coded into 4 categories: legacy media (tv/broadcast, newspaper and magazine) and digital-born media

Information reliability - Third-party journalistic tool: NewsGuard. Team of trained journalists evaluated nine criteria of journalistic practices

Media partisanship - five-level scale (1 = very liberal, somewhat liberal, middle of the road, somewhat conservative, and 5 = very conservative) report from ComScore PlanMetrix database

Education, income, gender and age - averaged - audience data of media outlets taken from PlanMetrix

d. Analysis

Authors calculated the relative visibility of each outlet on a platform by subtracting the web traffic index from the engagement index for the platform. They then leveraged OLS regressions to regress this metric against the variables discussed above. For H3, they included the quadratic term of media partisanship in the regression model.

3. Results and Conclusions

a. Answers to RQs and Hypotheses

H1a was supported for all platforms, H1b was partially supported (only for Twitter), and H1c was not supported.

H2 was partially supported only regarding Twitter.

H3 was supported.

H4 was not supported.

H5a was supported, and H5b was partially supported regarding Facebook and YouTube.

H6 was not supported.

H7 was not supported.

The effect of broadcast/TV (compared to digital-born outlets) was only significant for Twitter, while this effect became nonsignificant for YouTube and seemingly moved in the opposite direction (while still nonsignificant) for Facebook. Second, they observed particular effects related to news inequalities. The effect exacerbating the age gaps only appeared for Facebook, but it was not significant for Twitter or YouTube.

b. Include Key Figures/Tables

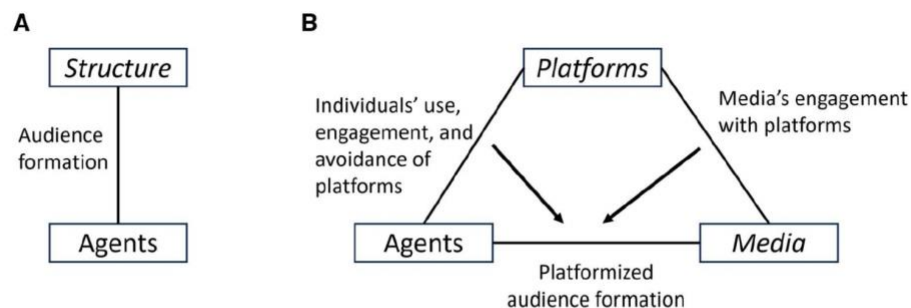


Figure 1. Theoretical framework. Panel A illustrates the original structuration theory, while Panel B highlights platforms and media as two prominent structural factors. This theoretical move prompted us to consider three relationships, paying particular attention to how platformized audience formation (the agent-media dyad) is shaped by the other two dyads.

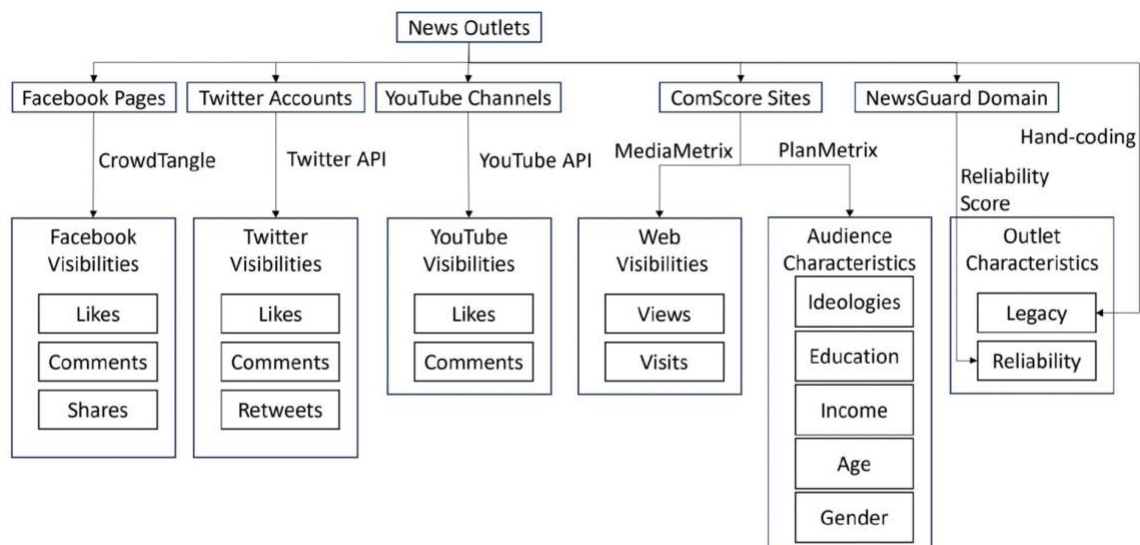
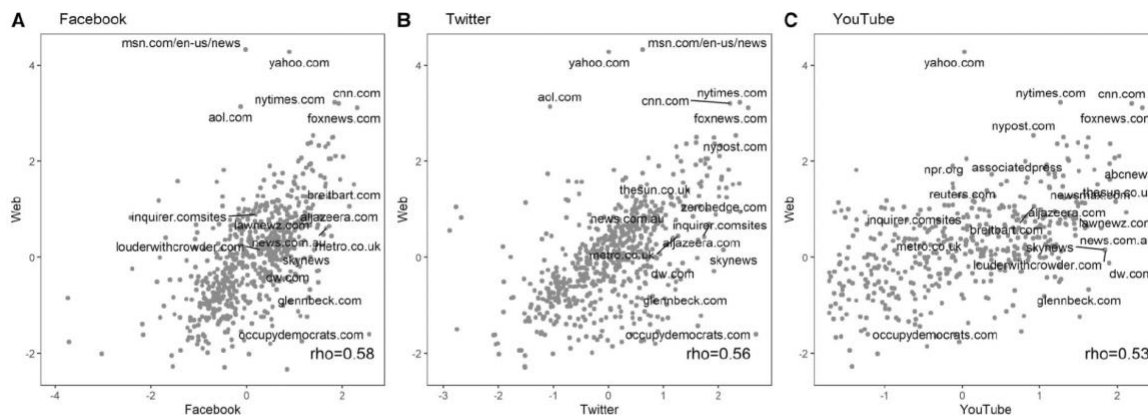
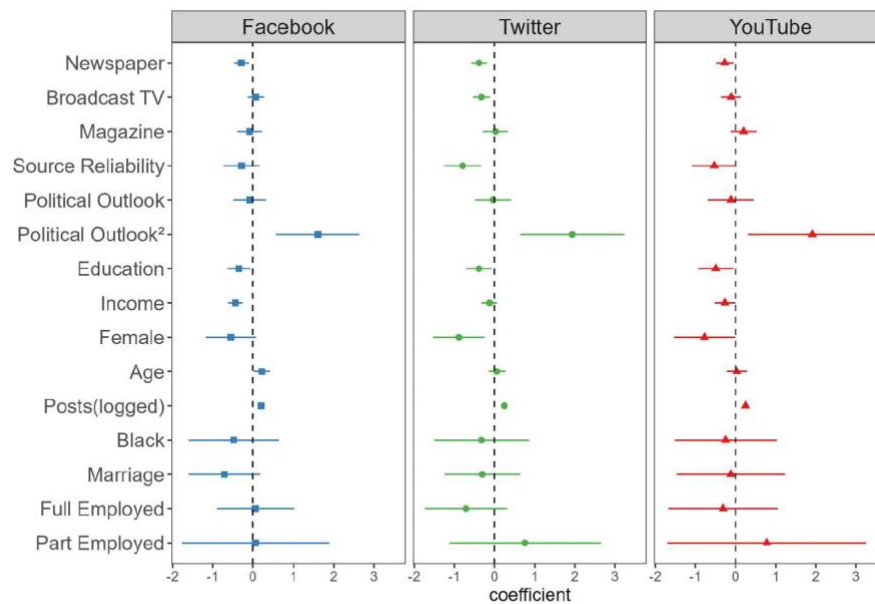


Figure 2. Overview of data collection. The figure shows the data sources used in this study.



c. Authors' Conclusions

“Media outlets that were digital-born (compared to newspapers), partisan, and mass-oriented gained greater visibilities on platforms relative to their web traffic. Meanwhile, the three platforms displayed differences. For example, only Twitter showed significantly increased visibilities of unreliable sources. Our multiplatform research design demonstrates the impact of platformization on journalism.”

4. Discussion

a. Implications

- The study showed that social media platforms actively reshape media power by amplifying digital-born and partisan outlets while producing mixed consequences for information quality, political polarization, and news inequality.
- Theoretically, this study extended the structuration theory by introducing platforms and media as separate structures.

b. Limitations

- Specific dynamic processes underlying structuration are not characterized.
- Didn't examine the specific content strategies employed by news media.
- Limited to only three platforms.
- Only limited to USA

c. Future Directions

- Above limitations can be overcome by:
- Media metrics that gauge public attention should be considered in structuration scholarship
- Include news organizations strategies
- Include visual oriented platforms: TikTok and Instagram
- Other information platforms such as search engines and news aggregators.
- Other societies, especially Global South.

d. ...

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Response Letter (~600 words)

- Your assessment of the study
- Weaknesses
- Other notes

This study has a robust design, and I believe it contributes to the journalism field both theoretically and methodologically with substantial value. The multiplatform design and the inclusion of four major factors that are directly related to news organization characteristics allow the authors to extend structuration theory by showing that structure can be divided between platforms and media, creating multiple dyads among agents, platforms, and media in shaping visibility, exposure, and engagement with news content on social media. It was particularly interesting to read the authors' justification for selecting the four factors to examine audience engagement as an indicator of platformized visibility.

Overall, the study design was strong in integrating multiple data sources, including ComScore and CrowdTangle, and in measuring differences in news exposure based on media characteristics across social media platforms. The scale of the data and the multiplatform approach offer significant theoretical contributions, especially in understanding how platformization reshapes media power. The finding on the prominence of unreliable information on Twitter was particularly insightful, as it suggests that certain platforms are more likely to propagate unreliable information or mis and disinformation.

However, I believe that information reliability and media partisanship should have been given greater priority, as the large number of independent variables makes the article somewhat unfocused and analytically diffuse. The institutional legacy variable appears less theoretically important, and removing it would not substantially affect the core argument of the study. Similarly, I am not fully convinced that the way news inequality is operationalized, through audience demographics such as gender, age, income, and education, adequately captures meaningful inequalities in access to news. In particular, focusing on women, older audiences, and lower income or lower education groups may oversimplify the concept of news inequality and does not necessarily reflect structural barriers to information. Excluding or reconceptualizing this factor would likely strengthen the theoretical coherence of the study rather than weaken it.

In general, I am more critical of the study in terms of using a large volume of data to examine platformized visibility while relying on engagement values as proxies for exposure. The presence of multiple hypotheses that were not supported also raises questions about whether the conceptual framework was too broad. I think the study design could have benefited more from using proprietary data traces to capture visibility more accurately, especially given the limitations of engagement metrics as indicators of actual exposure.

Although the authors provided a clear rationale for selecting the three social media platforms and acknowledged their specific affordances, YouTube stood out as a somewhat problematic case. YouTube displays the number of views of uploaded videos, but the authors did not use this metric, as they aimed to apply consistent engagement measures across platforms. At the same time, YouTube may not be an ideal platform for studying news exposure, as users often visit it primarily for entertainment or learning purposes rather than for news. My impression is that people selectively seek out news videos on YouTube, which makes exposure patterns fundamentally different from those on platforms such as Twitter or Facebook.

Additionally, although the theoretical framework emphasizes individual users as agents, the empirical analysis is conducted at the organizational level. This creates a gap between theory and method, as conclusions about user behavior cannot be directly supported without individual level data. While the organizational approach is useful for identifying structural patterns, it limits the ability to make claims about how audiences actually experience or interpret news content.

Overall, I think the study design is robust and well executed, offering important methodological and theoretical contributions to computational journalism research. At the same time, the study highlights key limitations related to measurement, conceptual focus, and the mismatch between theory and data, which future research should address.